

The Breakaway

Hailed as the great new hope for Indian men's tennis after making the Chennai Open final, Somdev Devvarman's success will lie in walking down his own road

By Sharda Ugra

Two days before Christmas, Somdev Devvarman sat on a chair in Delhi and said thoughtfully that the most instructive lesson in his recent tennis education had been throwing up. Not the act per se, but throwing up as a threshold, a limit, a medical condition even. The fellow had just stepped off a flight from the United States a few hours earlier, so that notion could have been explained by jet lag, lack of sleep, disorientation, a dozen TV interviews. But no. The mop-top, suddenly burst upon India as its No. 1 men's tennis player, was sure.

He had just spent three weeks training with Andy Roddick, world No. 9 and former US Open champion, and had been given a glimpse of the kind of players who inhabit tennis' highest orders. The kind that stepped onto court or the training ground and didn't step off until they had put their gut through a washing machine. With Roddick he had absorbed tennis lessons in, "professionalism, work ethic, intensity—all the stuff that's underrated". Away from the lights of centre court, pro tennis was, Devvarman said, "a mental grind. You have to run till you puke—you have to be willing to do the work. That's what it takes."

Well, what have we here? The Indian tennis player as neither touch artist nor showman, but as an artisan; not poetry in motion but a study in sweat. But India will take whatever comes its way because in the 13-year-history of its biggest men's tournament, the Chennai Open, Devvarman was the first Indian finalist. That performance carried him 48 spots up the ATP ranking list to a career-best of 154—the first time any Indian had made it into the top 200 after Leander Paes in December 1992. One Indian, top 200, 16 years: those are a miserable set of numbers.

Naturally he is called, "The One" so often now that he must feel like Keanu Reeves teleporting between hope and expectation. More hyperbolic anointment has him down as the 'Messiah', to which the most appropriate response is a Devvarmanesque, "Woah! Easy, dude."

Yet, the excitement is easy to un-

derstand though: over the past decade Indian men's tennis has existed in a wasteland of broken promises and personal animosity. Vishaal Uppal, former Davis Cupper and India representative of Mamba International, who handles Devvarman's commercial affairs, says, "In the last 10 years, Indian tennis has been in a shambles because of the bickering between Paes and Mahesh Bhupathi." It is not merely Paes and Bhupathi's burden to bear: all those who lined up on opposing sides and fuelled it, tried to influence other young men and public opinion this way or that, have Indian tennis' lost decade on their conscience.

In this dispiriting scenario, Devvarman comes as a breakaway. In terms of his game to India, he already is: a trademark modern pro, he hits a heavy ball, has wheels for feet, uses the expanse of the back court as his personal geometry notebook and has legs and lungs built to endure.

In his career, he has gone his own way too: completing his bachelor's degree at the University of Virginia when the temptation to turn pro early must have been seductive. He excelled at collegiate tennis while majoring in sociology, with a special interest in conflict issues (firmly excluding those around the current Indian Davis Cup team). He

writes poetry, plays guitar with two buddies on the odd night at a local bar in Charlottesville and makes sure that his family is distanced from his tennis decisions.

But what can really set him apart is neither his game nor these early results. If anything, it will be his clarity of purpose. The willingness to choose the difficult option. To invest time in perfecting the mechanics of his game and excelling in those underrated arts—professionalism, work ethic, intensity. Because he knows it is the only way to wring every last ounce of his gift. It is a common-enough idea, but one hardly followed through in our game. It is why less than a full year into his pro career, there is such a fuss about the guy with the grin.

It is why Somdev Devvarman must take the road less travelled. To show that it can be done. To turn on the light in Indian tennis again. ■

Somdev is a prototype of the modern player, neither artist nor showman, but a study in sweat.

